FiTEN Business Directory

Proposal & Implementation Plan

Connecting Tamil Entrepreneurs — Across Borders, Across Industries, Year-Round

Prepared for	FiTEN Executive Committee
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Executive Summary

FiTEN already has the network. Forty years of FeTNA conventions, speaker rosters, exhibitor halls, and business award ceremonies have built a Tamil entrepreneur community that no platform can replicate from scratch. **The missing piece is infrastructure**: a way for that network to be searched, accessed, and leveraged year-round — not just at the annual event.

This is not about building a better search engine for Tamil restaurants — Google does that well. This is about building the **infrastructure for Tamil B2B commerce**: a platform where a Tamil founder in New Jersey finds a software agency in Coimbatore, where a Tamil VC in Silicon Valley discovers a startup in Chennai, where a FiTEN speaker's profile persists and grows long after their session ends.

- Enable Tamil B2B connections: partnerships, vendor sourcing, investment, mentorship
- Bridge Tamil businesses across US and India with cross-border Tamil B2B context
- Generate sustainable revenue to fund FiTEN operations year-round
- Create the only searchable investor–startup pipeline for Tamil-founded companies globally
- Give FiTEN event attendees a permanent professional presence beyond the event

ABOUT FiTEN & FeTNA

FiTEN (International Tamil Entrepreneurs Network) is a flagship initiative of **FeTNA** — the Federation of Tamil Sangams of North America, a **40-year-old** organization representing Tamil communities across the US and Canada through **100+ regional Sangams** and **20+ annual conventions**. FiTEN focuses specifically on the entrepreneur and professional segment: founders, investors, executives, and business owners across technology, healthcare, finance, real estate, and more. The Business Directory makes this network **searchable, persistent, and commercially valuable** — 365 days a year.

~600K	71	3,000+
Tamil People in the US & Canada	**Member Tamil Sangams in FeTNA**	**FeTNA Convention Attendees (2025)**
US & Canadian Census	FeTNA.org verified	South Asian Herald, 2025

PROBLEM, OPPORTUNITY & COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

THE PROBLEM	THE OPPORTUNITY
• No dedicated platform for Tamil B2B discovery, vendor sourcing, or investor-startup matching. • FiTEN event connections disappear when the conference ends — no persistent directory. • Tamil businesses across US and India cannot find each other by cultural context. • No centralized way to discover Tamil startups and connect them with investors. • No trust-verified directory — a "Verified FiTEN Member" badge has no digital home.	• FeTNA's 40-year credibility provides a unique trust foundation no competitor can replicate. • Tamil professionals are among the most educated and highest-earning immigrant communities in North America — entrepreneurship is growing rapidly. • No platform combines Tamil identity, B2B networking, investor-startup matching, and event integration. • The directory becomes the year-round digital home of FiTEN.

Competitive Landscape

None of the following platforms serve the B2B networking and community trust use cases that are FiTEN's core opportunity:

Platform	Tamil-Specific	Bilingual	Key Gap vs. FiTEN
Google / Google Maps	**No**	**No**	No Tamil B2B networking, no trust layer, no investor matching, no FiTEN event identity.
LinkedIn	**No**	**No**	No Tamil filter, no community badge, no diaspora specificity.
Tamil Business Pages (Facebook)	**Partial**	**Partial**	Groups only — no searchable directory, no verified badges, no investment signals.
YellowPages / Yelp	**No**	**No**	Consumer-facing. No B2B networking, no Tamil identity, no community trust infrastructure.
India-specific directories	**Partial**	**Partial**	India-only scope. No FeTNA layer, no US-India cross-border view, no investor matching.
FiTEN Directory (proposed)	**✓ YES**	**✓ YES**	**The ONLY platform combining Tamil B2B networking, investor-startup matching, cross-border commerce, FiTEN event identity, and community trust.**

THE PROPOSED SOLUTION

The FiTEN Business Directory is a year-round B2B networking platform and business registry built into fiten.org — the organised, searchable, and persistent version of the network FiTEN has already built through its annual events. Six core pillars define what makes it uniquely valuable:

1. Tamil B2B Networking	The primary purpose is connection, not just search. Profiles include signals: "Open to Partnership / Seeking Investment / Available for Mentorship / Looking for Co-founder." Tamil entrepreneurs find each other by industry, geography, stage, and intent.
2. Investor–Startup Pipeline	Startups flag investment stage and sector. Tamil VCs and investors filter by Tamil-founded, stage, sector, and geography — the only structured Tamil investor-startup matching infrastructure in existence.
3. Cross-Border Commerce (US+India)	Explicitly bridges Tamil entrepreneurs across the US and India. Indian tech agencies signal interest in US Tamil clients; US founders find culturally-aligned vendors in India. Cross-border filters and bilingual profiles serve both sides.
4. Persistent FiTEN Event Identity	FiTEN speakers, exhibitors, and award winners receive permanent profile links. Speaker sessions, exhibitor years, and awards persist on directory profiles indefinitely — a 3-day event becomes a permanent professional credential.
5. Community-Verified Trust	"Verified FiTEN Member" badge awarded based on active membership — not listing tier. Backed by FeTNA's 40-year history, this social signal means something no algorithm can replicate. Peer reviews from FiTEN members add further social proof.
6. Tamil Cultural Context	Full bilingual interface in English and Tamil script. Tamil-language descriptions, Tamil search, and Tamil UI serve both diaspora and Tamil Nadu-based businesses. Cultural calendar integration connects listings to Tamil festivals and FeTNA events.

Key Features by Phase

Feature	Description	Phase
Search & Filter	Full-text search + filters: category, location, language, member status, business size.	Phase 1
Business Profiles	Rich listing pages: logo, description (EN at launch), contact, website, socials.	Phase 1
Self-Service Portal + Admin	Business owners register and manage listings; FiTEN staff approve/reject submissions.	Phase 1
Mobile Responsive	Fully optimised for smartphones — primary access device for diaspora users.	Phase 1
Tamil Language (Full)	Full EN+Tamil bilingual interface, Tamil-script descriptions, Tamil search queries.	Phase 2
Verified Badges	FiTEN Member, FiTEN Speaker, Women-Led, Minority Business badges with review process.	Phase 2
B2B Connection Requests	Send/receive requests with intent: partnership, investment, co-founder, mentorship.	Phase 2
FiTEN Event History	Speaker sessions, exhibitor years, and awards persist on profiles indefinitely.	Phase 2
Investor–Startup Matching	Founders flag stage/sector; investors filter by Tamil-founded, stage, sector, geography.	Phase 3

Analytics Dashboard	Profile views, clicks, connection requests, and B2B inquiry volume for listing owners.	Phase 3
Sponsored Placements	Paid banner ads, sponsored search results, and curated editorial collections.	Phase 3
AI Recommendations + API	AI-powered matching; Tamil Nadu startup registry integration; global Tamil association API.	Phase 4

Phase key: Gold = Phase 1 (Mo 1–3) | Teal = Phase 2 (Mo 4–6) | Red = Phase 3 (Mo 7–9) | Blue = Phase 4 (Mo 10+)

MONETIZATION STRATEGY

Revenue unlocks phase by phase — customers never pay for features not yet live. **The "Verified FiTEN Member" badge is free** for all active members; paid tiers provide enhanced visibility and reach, not verification.

Listing Tiers — Phased Unlock

FREE	SILVER $9/mo · $99/yr	GOLD $22/mo · $229/yr	PLATINUM $42/mo · $449/yr
Name, category & location	All Free features	All Silver features	All Gold features
Contact info & website	Logo & photos (up to 5)	Priority search placement	Homepage featured spotlight
Full description (EN)	Social media links	Tamil description (EN+Tamil)	Sponsored search result
Verified Member badge	Customer reviews enabled	Email digest inclusion	Dedicated feature article
	FeTNA life member benefit	Owner analytics dashboard*	FiTEN event booth discount (10%)

** Analytics dashboard activates Phase 3. Monthly billing at slight premium. FeTNA life members receive one complimentary Silver listing.*

Additional Revenue Streams + Projections

Banner Advertising	$300–$800/mo per category. Activates Phase 2.
Event Exhibitor Bundle	Platinum listing included in exhibitor package. $200/exhibitor.
Job Board	Tamil businesses hire Tamil professionals. $75/posting, 60 days. Phase 2.
Curated Sponsored Lists	Editorial collections (e.g., "Top Tamil Tech in NJ"). $200–$400 featured. Phase 2.
State of Tamil Business Report	Annual data report. $199 individual / $799 institutional. Year 2+.

Revenue Stream	Year 1 (ramp-up)	Year 2 (steady state)
Silver listings (60 × 9 mo avg)	$5,400	$10,890 (110 × $99)
Gold listings (20 × 6 mo avg)	$2,290	$9,160 (40 × $229)
Platinum listings (8 × 3 mo avg)	$900	$4,490 (10 × $449)
Banner advertising (avg $400/mo, 6 mo)	$2,400	$7,200
Event exhibitor bundles (15 × $200)	$3,000	$5,000 (25 × $200)
Job board + curated lists	$2,100	$10,000

State of Tamil Business Report	—	$4,000
Total	**~$16,090**	**~$50,740**

Key assumptions: 75% annual renewal rate. Year 2 assumes 30% organic listing growth. Year 1 is deliberately conservative.

ROLLOUT PLAN

Phase	Timeline	Deliverables & Milestones
Phase 1	**Months 1–3**	English-only directory: search, browse, rich profiles, 20+ category taxonomy, self-service portal, admin dashboard, mobile-optimised. Language toggle with Tamil "Coming Soon." Silver tier opens. 100 founding member listings onboarded.
Phase 2	**Months 4–6**	Full Tamil language + bilingual profiles, Verified Member badges, community reviews, B2B connection requests, partnership signals, FiTEN event integration, cross-border filters, email digest. Gold tier opens.
Phase 3	**Months 7–9**	Investor–startup matching, co-founder search, owner analytics dashboard, banner advertising, sponsored placements, curated lists, API access for Tamil associations globally. Platinum tier opens.
Phase 4	**Month 10+**	AI-powered recommendations, Tamil Nadu government startup registry integration, multi-city curated guides, affiliate/referral programs. State of Tamil Business Report first publication.

Launch Strategy

- **Pre-launch:** Recruit 100 founding listings from FiTEN/FeTNA network — free lifetime Silver tier as incentive.
- **Soft launch:** FiTEN Edison NJ event — live demo kiosk, QR code sign-up, founding business showcase.
- **Social campaign:** #TamilBusiness across FeTNA Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, X — 100K+ combined reach.
- **Community outreach:** Partner with 100+ Tamil Sangams across the US and Canada.
- **Press coverage:** Pitch to Tamil media — Aruvi Magazine, FeTNA Radio, Tamil press in US and India.

TECHNOLOGY ARCHITECTURE

Frontend	Next.js (React) — fast, SEO-optimised, server-side rendering.
Backend / API	Node.js with REST or GraphQL API — community-friendly for open-source contributions.
Database	PostgreSQL — relational data with full-text search.
Search	Algolia — fast, typo-tolerant search. Free tier up to 10K searches/mo; $50–$100/mo at scale.
Hosting	Vercel (frontend) + AWS/DigitalOcean (backend/DB). $50–$150/month Year 1.
Auth / Payments	Auth0 or Clerk (Google/LinkedIn/email login) + Stripe (subscription tiers).
Tamil / Email	Google Noto Sans Tamil + i18next localisation. SendGrid for digests and notifications.
Privacy & Security	GDPR + CCPA compliant. SSL/TLS, 90-day backups, admin listing review before go-live.

TEAM, GOVERNANCE & RISK ASSESSMENT

Team & Governance

Directory Lead	Designated FiTEN board member or committee chair. Owns the roadmap, vendor relationships, quarterly reviews. Reports to Executive Committee.
Community Outreach Lead	Recruits founding listings, manages outreach to Tamil Sangams, oversees member badge verification process.
Technical Lead	Volunteer developer(s) from FiTEN community who own the codebase. Contracted agency as fallback if volunteer bandwidth is insufficient for Phase 1.
Content & Moderation	Reviews and approves listing submissions, manages spam and flagged content. 2–3 volunteer moderators.
Tamil Language Review	Tamil-fluent community reviewers who validate UI strings, business descriptions, and search result quality.

All policy changes require FiTEN Executive Committee approval. Quarterly metric reviews. Annual community survey. Open-source codebase on GitHub.

Risk Assessment

Risk	Impact	Likelihood	Mitigation
Low listing adoption	**High**	**Medium**	100 founding member listings pre-launch. Free lifetime Silver tier incentive. Dedicated community outreach lead.
Fake / fraudulent listings	**High**	**Medium**	Admin approval required before go-live. Post-approval flagging. FiTEN badge requires active membership verification.
Volunteer developer bandwidth	**High**	**High**	Contracted agency fallback. 3 volunteer developers identified and committed before kick-off.
Tamil localization quality	**Medium**	**Medium**	Tamil-fluent FeTNA reviewers for UI strings. Professional translator for launch copy.
Funding gap before revenue	**Medium**	**Low**	Phase 1 ($8K–$15K) funded from FiTEN event surplus or targeted pre-launch sponsorship.
Competition / differentiation	**Low**	**Low**	FiTEN's member-verified trust layer and 40-year FeTNA credibility are an irreplicable moat.

SUCCESS METRICS — YEAR 1 TARGETS

Tracked quarterly. Phase 2 features activate Month 4; Phase 3 features Month 7.

GROWTH & REACH	
Total Listings	**350+**
New Listings/Month	**20+/mo by Q4**
Monthly Active Users	**4,000–5,000**
Search Sessions/Month	**10,000+**
Organic Search Traffic	**30%+ by Q4**

ENGAGEMENT & QUALITY	
Listing Completion Rate	**70%+**
Email Digest Open Rate	**35%+**
Profile Return Visits	**50%+**

B2B NETWORKING (Phase 2+)	
Connection Requests/Month	**75+/mo by EOY1**
Connection Acceptance Rate	**50%+**
Partnership Signal Adoption	**30%+**
Investor Profiles Created	**15+ by EOY1**

COMMUNITY TRUST & REVENUE	
Verified Badge Rate	**60%+**
Tamil Language Usage	**20%+**
Community Reviews	**150+**
Paid Conversion Rate	**10–13%**
Listing Renewal Rate	**70%+**
Year 1 Revenue	**~$16,000**

BUDGET SUMMARY

Phase 1 Development	$8,000–$15,000 contracted | $0–$2,000 volunteer-led. Design, front-end, back-end, admin panel, database.

Phase 2 Development	$3,000–$6,000 incremental: Tamil localisation, badge system, B2B connections, event integration.
Phase 3 Development	$2,000–$4,000 incremental: Stripe, analytics dashboard, investor matching, sponsored listings.
Hosting + Search + Email	$50–$150/mo hosting + ~$400–$800/yr Algolia + SendGrid. Year 1 total: ~$1,200–$2,600.
Translation (professional)	$500–$1,500 for initial UI strings and launch copy. Ongoing: community volunteer.
Total Year 1 Budget	**$12,000–$25,000 (contracted)** or **$3,000–$7,000 (volunteer-led).** Covered by ~$16,000 Year 1 revenue.

Recommended: Phase 1 from FiTEN event surplus. Phases 2–3 self-funded from directory revenue.

RECOMMENDED NEXT STEPS

1. Board Approval	*Within 30 days*	Present to FiTEN Executive Committee for formal approval and Phase 1 budget authorisation.
2. Appoint Directory Lead	*Within 30 days*	Designate a FiTEN board member or trusted community leader as project owner.
3. Developer Recruitment	*30–45 days*	Open call to FiTEN/FeTNA communities. Target: 2–3 volunteer developers committed before contracting.
4. Founding Listings Drive	*Ongoing from Day 1*	Recruit 100 founding listings from existing FiTEN member network. Offer: free lifetime Silver tier.
5. Design & Build Phase 1	*90 days from kick-off*	Phase 1 development with milestone reviews at 45 days (alpha) and 75 days (beta with founding listings).
6. FiTEN Event Soft Launch	*Next major FiTEN/FeTNA event*	Live kiosk demo, QR code sign-up, and founding business showcase at the event.
7. Phase 2 Planning	*60 days post-launch*	Review Phase 1 metrics and begin Phase 2 planning: Tamil UI, badge system, B2B connections, investor matching.

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